

Analyzing Poetry

Readers encounter poetry everywhere: in textbooks, on social media, in song lyrics, even on subway walls. But what makes a poem a poem? Poetry has distinguishing features – ideas, structure, language, and purpose – that set it apart from other forms of writing. Yet poetry is also endlessly adaptable. Poets borrow from tradition, break rules, invent new forms, and blur boundaries between genres. Understanding how poets make these choices is the first step toward writing poetry oneself.

Creative writing is the craft of shaping language to create meaning, emotion, and beauty. Poetry demands attention to every word, every sound, every space on the page. This inquiry unit asks readers to become analysts – to examine how poets use and adapt structure and language across traditional, contemporary, and digital poetic forms, and to recognize how poets establish their individual voices. It also asks readers to consider ethical questions about AI attribution, plagiarism, and poetic borrowing.

This reading material distinguishes the key features of poetry based on ideas, structure, language, and purpose. It compares how poets adapt structure and language across forms, examines how poets play with genre conventions to convey emotion and commentary, and recognizes ethical considerations in developing one's own poetic style.

Part 1: What Is Poetry and How Can It Be Distinguished from Other Genres?

Definition of Poetry

Poetry is a genre of literature that uses aesthetic and rhythmic qualities of language – such as sound symbolism, meter, imagery, and figurative language – to evoke meanings and emotional responses beyond literal interpretation.

The Central Question: What Makes a Poem a Poem?

Poetry is notoriously difficult to define. However, readers can distinguish poetry from prose (fiction, essays, journalism) by examining four key features: ideas, structure, language, and purpose.

Key Features of Poetry

Feature	What to Look For	How It Differs from Prose
Ideas	Concentrated, layered, often abstract or emotional	Prose develops ideas linearly over paragraphs; poetry compresses ideas into images and moments
Structure	Line breaks, stanzas, white space, visual arrangement	Prose uses sentences and paragraphs; poetry uses lines and stanzas deliberately
Language	Figurative (metaphor, simile, personification), condensed, musical	Prose prioritizes clarity and denotation; poetry prioritizes connotation and sound
Purpose	To evoke emotion, create beauty, reveal insight, or provoke thought	Prose may inform or persuade; poetry emphasizes aesthetic and emotional experience

Ideas in Poetry

Aspect	Description	Example
Compression	Poetry says more with fewer words	"Hope is the thing with feathers" (Emily Dickinson) – an abstract idea captured in a single image

Abstraction	Poetry often explores love, death, grief, joy, identity	"I have measured out my life with coffee spoons" (T.S. Eliot) – existential weariness through a concrete image
Implication	What is left unsaid is as important as what is said	Gaps and silences invite reader interpretation
Emotional core	Poetry prioritizes how an idea feels, not just what it means	"I, too, sing America" (Langston Hughes) – pride and protest through a simple declaration

Structure in Poetry

Structural Element	Description	Example
Line break	Where a line ends; creates rhythm, emphasis, or ambiguity	"so much depends / upon" (William Carlos Williams) – the break creates suspense
Stanza	A grouped set of lines (like a paragraph in prose)	Couplet (2 lines), tercet (3), quatrain (4), etc.
White space	Empty space on the page; creates silence, pause, or separation	E.E. Cummings' unconventional spacing
Meter	Pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables	Iambic pentameter (da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM)
Rhyme scheme	Pattern of end rhymes (ABAB, AABB, etc.)	"The woods are lovely, dark and deep, / But I have promises to keep"

Language in Poetry

Language Feature	Description	Example
Figurative language	Metaphor, simile, personification, hyperbole	"My love is a red, red rose" (Robert Burns) – metaphor
Imagery	Sensory details (sight, sound, smell, touch, taste)	"I saw the best minds of my generation destroyed by madness" (Allen Ginsberg) – visual and emotional
Sound devices	Alliteration, assonance, consonance, onomatopoeia	"The silken, sad, uncertain rustling of each purple curtain" (Edgar Allan Poe) – alliteration and assonance
Diction	Word choice (formal, colloquial, archaic, invented)	"th gst tu bcome a name" (E.E. Cummings) – invented spelling and syntax

Purpose in Poetry

Purpose	Description	Example
Emotional expression	To convey feeling that cannot be expressed in plain language	Sylvia Plath's confessional poems
Commentary	To critique society, politics, or culture	"The Second Coming" (W.B. Yeats) – commentary on post-WWI chaos
Aesthetic beauty	To create pleasure through language and sound	Keats' odes to beauty and art

Purpose	Description	Example
Insight	To reveal a truth about human experience	"The Road Not Taken" (Robert Frost) – reflection on choice and identity

Part 2: Comparing Poetic Forms – Traditional, Contemporary, and Digital

Poets do not all write the same way. Some follow strict rules of meter, rhyme, and line length (traditional forms). Others break those rules or invent new ones (contemporary forms). Still others write for screens, using hyperlinks, images, motion, and interaction (digital poetry). Understanding how poets adapt structure and language across these forms reveals their artistic intentions.

Traditional Poetic Forms

Traditional forms follow established rules about meter, rhyme scheme, line length, and stanza structure.

Form	Key Features	Example Poet
Sonnet	14 lines, iambic pentameter, specific rhyme scheme (Shakespearean: ABAB CDCD EFEF GG; Petrarchan: ABBA ABBA CDE CDE)	William Shakespeare
Haiku	3 lines, syllable pattern 5-7-5, nature theme	Matsuo Bashō
Villanelle	19 lines, two repeating rhymes, two refrains (lines repeat)	Dylan Thomas ("Do not go gentle into that good night")
Sestina	39 lines, six repeating end-words in a rotating pattern	Elizabeth Bishop

Form	Key Features	Example Poet
Limerick	5 lines, AABBA rhyme scheme, humorous	Edward Lear
Elegy	Mourns the dead; no fixed form but specific subject matter	Walt Whitman ("When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd")

Contemporary Poetic Forms

Contemporary poets often adapt or reject traditional rules. They may use free verse (no regular meter or rhyme), prose poetry (poems written as paragraphs), or invented forms.

Form	Key Features	Example Poet
Free verse	No regular meter, no required rhyme; uses line breaks, white space, and imagery for effect	Walt Whitman, Allen Ginsberg, Mary Oliver
Prose poem	Written in paragraph form, no line breaks, but uses poetic language and compression	Claudia Rankine, Charles Baudelaire
Spoken word / performance poetry	Written for oral performance; uses rhythm, repetition, and audience interaction	Saul Williams, Sarah Kay
Blackout poetry	Created by redacting words from an existing text (newspaper, book page)	Austin Kleon
Erasure poetry	Similar to blackout; the poet erases most words, leaving a new poem	Mary Ruefle
Found poetry	Takes existing non-poetic texts (advertisements, instructions, letters) and arranges them as poetry	Various

Digital Poetic Forms

Digital poetry (e-poetry) is written for or adapted to digital platforms. It uses technology as part of the poem's meaning.

Form	Key Features	Example
Hypertext poetry	Uses hyperlinks to create non-linear reading paths; reader chooses the order	"The Unknown" (William Gillespie)
Kinetic poetry	Words move, change color, appear/disappear on screen	Electronic Literature Collection
Interactive poetry	Reader interacts (clicks, types, chooses) to generate or reveal lines	Various web-based works
Video poetry	Combines spoken word, music, and moving images	YouTube poetry channels (Button Poetry, Write About Now)
Instagram / social media poetry	Short, visual, designed for scrolling; often includes images with overlaid text	Rupi Kaur, Atticus

How Poets Adapt Structure and Language Across Forms

Form	Structural Adaptation	Language Adaptation
Sonnet (traditional)	Follows 14-line, iambic pentameter structure	Formal diction, elevated vocabulary, end rhymes
Free verse (contemporary)	No fixed meter; line breaks create emphasis	Colloquial diction, enjambment, internal rhythm
Instagram poetry (digital)	Very short lines, frequent white space, centered alignment	Simple vocabulary, aphoristic style, emotional directness

Form	Structural Adaptation	Language Adaptation
Spoken word (performance)	Built for breath and oral delivery; repetition as structure	Conversational, rhythmic, repetitive, with audience address

Part 3: How Poets Use and Play with Conventions of Genre

Genre conventions are the expected features of a particular genre (e.g., sonnets have 14 lines; elegies mourn the dead). Poets may follow conventions, break them deliberately, or play with them to create meaning.

Following Conventions

Convention	Example	Effect
Sonnet follows 14-line structure	Shakespeare's Sonnet 18 ("Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?")	Creates expectation of turn (volta) at line 9 or couplet
Elegy expresses grief	"When Lilacs Last in the Dooryard Bloom'd" (Whitman)	Signals mourning; invites shared grief

Breaking Conventions Deliberately

Broken Convention	Example	Effect
Sonnet with fewer than 14 lines	"Sonnet" (Robert Creeley, 12 lines)	Creates unease; questions what a sonnet is
Haiku about urban life (not nature)	"Haiku" (Jack Kerouac: "Snow in my shoe / Abandoned / Sparrow's nest")	Creates irony; comments on modern alienation

Broken Convention	Example	Effect
Elegy that refuses grief	"One Art" (Elizabeth Bishop) – uses villanelle form to explore loss as mastery	Suggests repression; emotional complexity beneath surface

Playing with Conventions for Thematic Effect

Poetic Play	Example	Thematic Effect
Using sonnet form for a mundane subject	"Sonnet" (Billy Collins) – a sonnet about writing a sonnet	Humor; self-awareness; democratizing poetry
Writing an elegy for a living person	"Elegy for My Father, Who Is Not Dead" (Andrew Hudgins)	Explores anticipatory grief; fear of loss
Using epic form for a domestic subject	"Song of Myself" (Whitman) – epic scale for everyday American life	Elevates ordinary experience to heroic status

Conveying Emotion, Theme, or Commentary through Genre Choices

Intent	How Genre Conventions Convey It
Emotion	Sonnet form creates intimacy (confessional tone); elegy signals grief; haiku evokes quiet observation
Theme	Repetition in villanelle suggests obsession or inescapability; fragmentation suggests trauma or dislocation
Commentary	Using a traditional form for an unconventional subject critiques tradition; breaking form protests constraint

Part 4: Stylistic Differences Among Poets and Individual Voices

Just as every person has a unique speaking voice, every poet has a unique **poetic voice** – the combination of diction, syntax, imagery, rhythm, and subject matter that distinguishes one poet from another.

Features That Establish Poetic Voice

Feature	What to Look For	Poets Distinguished by This Feature
Diction (word choice)	Formal vs. casual; abstract vs. concrete; archaic vs. contemporary	Emily Dickinson (compressed, dashes, capitalizations); Whitman (catalogues, expansive)
Syntax (sentence structure)	Short vs. long; straightforward vs. inverted; fragmented vs. flowing	E.E. Cummings (lowercase, unconventional punctuation, invented words)
Imagery	Urban vs. natural; domestic vs. cosmic; violent vs. tender	William Carlos Williams (ordinary objects); Plath (medical, violent imagery)
Rhythm and sound	Regular meter vs. free verse; musical vs. stark; smooth vs. jarring	Poe (musical, repetitive); Ginsberg (long, breath-driven lines)
Subject matter	Themes and topics repeatedly explored	Neruda (odes to ordinary things); Frost (nature and rural life); Smith (contemporary grief and digital life)
Tone	Attitude toward subject (ironic, earnest, angry, tender, detached)	Bukowski (gritty, cynical); Mary Oliver (reverent, observant)

Comparing Stylistic Differences: Two Poets on Nature

Feature	William Wordsworth (Romantic)	Mary Oliver (Contemporary)
Diction	Elevated, formal ("a host of golden daffodils")	Simple, direct ("You do not have to be good.")
Syntax	Complex, inverted sentences	Short, declarative sentences
Tone	Reverent, transcendental	Intimate, conversational
Structure	Regular meter, stanzas	Free verse, variable line lengths
Purpose	To show nature's spiritual power	To offer instruction for living

How to Identify a Poet's Voice

Step	Action
1	Read multiple poems by the same poet
2	Note recurring word choices, subjects, and images
3	Identify patterns in line length, stanza structure, and punctuation
4	Describe the tone (How does the poet feel about their subject?)
5	Compare to another poet to see what makes each distinctive

Part 5: Ethical Considerations in Developing One's Poetic Style

As emerging poets, students must consider ethical questions about borrowing, influence, AI, and attribution. Poetry has a long tradition of allusion, homage, and borrowing. But there is a difference between influence and plagiarism.

Key Ethical Terms

Term	Definition	Example
Influence	The natural process of being shaped by writers one admires	Reading Dickinson and then experimenting with dashes
Allusion	A deliberate reference to another text, often for thematic effect	"I, too, sing America" (Hughes) alludes to Whitman
Homage	A work written in respectful tribute to another writer	"Homage to My Hips" (Clifton) echoes Whitman's style
Borrowing	Using a phrase, image, or structure from another poet without transformation	Questionable if uncredited
Plagiarism	Presenting another writer's work as one's own	Copying a poem and signing one's name
AI attribution	Failing to disclose that a poem was generated wholly or partly by artificial intelligence	Submitting ChatGPT-generated poetry as original work

Acceptable Borrowing vs. Plagiarism

Practice	Is It Ethical?	Condition
Reading widely and being influenced	Yes	Always
Using a traditional form (sonnet, haiku)	Yes	Forms are public domain
Echoing a phrase or image as homage	Yes	Must be recognizable as homage, not theft
Direct quotation with attribution	Yes	Use quotation marks or epigraph
Copying a poem and changing a few words	No	This is plagiarism
Submitting AI-generated poetry as original	No (unless disclosed)	Requires attribution

AI and Poetry: Emerging Ethical Questions

Question	Consideration
Can AI write poetry?	AI can generate text that resembles poetry, but lacks lived experience, intention, and emotion
Is it ethical to use AI for inspiration?	Possibly, if disclosed; using AI to generate prompts or drafts may be acceptable in some contexts
Is it ethical to submit AI-generated poetry as one's own?	No. Most academic and publication contexts prohibit this
Should AI-generated poetry be attributed?	Yes, if any part of the work is AI-generated, the writer should disclose this

Poetic Borrowing in Literary Tradition

Poetry has always been a conversation across time. Poets borrow from each other consciously and unconsciously. The key is **transformation**.

Type of Borrowing	Example	Ethical?
Direct copying without change	"The fog comes / on little cat feet" (Carl Sandburg) copied as one's own	No
Rewriting from a different perspective	"Homage to My Hips" (Lucille Clifton) echoes Whitman's catalogues but with a Black female voice	Yes
Using a line as an epigraph	Placing a line from another poet at the beginning of one's poem with attribution	Yes
Writing a response poem	"The Second Coming" (Yeats) inspires another poet's response to political chaos	Yes

Guidelines for Ethical Poetic Practice

Guideline	Explanation
Keep a reading journal	Record influences and favorite lines; acknowledge where ideas came from
When in doubt, attribute	If you borrow a distinctive phrase or image, credit the source
Transform, do not copy	Use influence as a starting point, then make it your own
Disclose AI use	If you use AI for drafting, editing, or inspiration, be transparent
Ask permission (for living poets)	If you want to quote extensively or write a direct homage, consider contacting the poet or their estate

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Poetry	A genre using aesthetic and rhythmic language to evoke emotional responses
Line break	Where a line of poetry ends; used for rhythm, emphasis, or ambiguity
Stanza	A grouped set of lines (like a paragraph)
Meter	Pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables
Free verse	Poetry with no regular meter or required rhyme
Traditional form	Poetry following established rules (sonnet, haiku, villanelle)
Contemporary form	Modern or invented forms (free verse, prose poem, spoken word)
Digital poetry	Poetry written for or adapted to digital platforms
Genre convention	Expected features of a particular poetic form
Poetic voice	The unique combination of diction, syntax, imagery, and tone that distinguishes a poet
Plagiarism	Presenting another writer's work as one's own
Allusion	Deliberate reference to another text
Homage	A work written in respectful tribute to another writer

Review Questions

1. Identify four key features that distinguish poetry from other genres (ideas, structure, language, purpose). For each feature, provide one example of what a reader should look for.

2. Complete the following table comparing traditional, contemporary, and digital poetic forms:

Feature	Traditional Form (e.g., sonnet)	Contemporary Form (e.g., free verse)	Digital Form (e.g., Instagram poetry)
Structure (line length, stanzas, rhyme)			
Language (diction, figurative language)			
Typical purpose			

3. Choose one traditional poetic form (sonnet, haiku, villanelle, or elegy). Explain how a poet might follow its conventions to convey a specific emotion. Then explain how a different poet might break those conventions for a different effect.

4. Read the two short poems below. Identify three stylistic differences between the two poets (diction, syntax, imagery, tone, or structure).

Poem A (Emily Dickinson): "Because I could not stop for Death – / He kindly stopped for me – / The Carriage held but just Ourselves – / And Immortality."

Poem B (Walt Whitman): "I celebrate myself, and sing myself, / And what I assume you shall assume, / For every atom belonging to me as good belongs to you."

- 5.** What is the difference between poetic influence and plagiarism? Provide one example of acceptable borrowing and one example of unacceptable borrowing.
- 6.** Explain an ethical consideration regarding the use of artificial intelligence (AI) in writing poetry. When is it acceptable? When is it not acceptable? What should a writer disclose?
- 7.** Define poetic voice. List three features of a poet's style that contribute to their individual voice.
- 8.** Application question: A student writes a poem that echoes the rhythm and imagery of a famous poet they admire. The student does not copy any words directly. Is this plagiarism? Is it ethical? Explain your reasoning.
- 9.** Identify two poets whose voices you can distinguish from each other. For each poet, describe one specific feature of their style that makes their voice recognizable.
- 10.** Reflection question: What is one traditional poetic form you would like to try writing? What would you keep from the traditional rules, and what might you adapt or break? Why?